

“Everyone should be extremely pleased that ... such **great love** could **reside** in a **woman's heart** in the **bond of marriage**.”

CHRISTINE DE PIZAN, *THE BOOK OF THE CITY OF LADIES*, 1405

EXPERIENCES OF MARRIAGE

Tying the knot

Love and marriage have not always gone hand in hand. Traditionally, marriage was often a far less romantic affair, serving as a way to join two families for economic or political reasons, in which a woman was passed from father to husband as property.

ALTHOUGH MARRIAGE is an ancient custom, until modern times it had little to do with love or being equal partners. Historically, a woman's family often selected her husband, particularly among social elites. Until the early 20th century, the marriages of nobility and royalty were about forging diplomatic and dynastic alliances. Such matches were often made while the bride and groom were children; in 1464 Louis XI of France arranged for his daughter Joan to marry her cousin, Louis of Orléans, just after she was born. Despite Joan being disabled and possibly sterile, the wedding itself took place when Joan was just 12 years old. Arranged marriages are still prevalent in some countries, such as

India, despite the recent rise in “love matches” in which parents are not involved. Indian arranged marriages require both spouses' consent, unlike forced marriages, which still occur in sub-Saharan Africa, Latin America, and South Asia. In forced unions it is most often the woman who is coerced into marrying, often at a young age.

Paying the price

A traditional pillar of a marriage contract has been the dowry—wealth that is given to the groom or his family by the bride's parents. In medieval Europe, the dowry was money or property, whereas in Tsarist Russia it often

consisted of linens and clothing for the bride herself to wear. Conversely, in some cultures, a “bride price” was paid by the family of the groom. This is still the case in Islamic marriages, in which the groom or his father

“A **maid marries according to the will of her parents; a widow decides her marriage by herself**.”

CHINESE PROVERB

